

Haligric Research Integration Series

BALINESE BELIEFS, RITUALS & TRADITIONS

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Island of the Gods — Agama Hindu Dharma, the Canang Sari, Gamelan, Ngaben, Nyepi, and the Living Sacred World of Bali

The Island of the Gods.

*An entire civilization organized around the continuous performance of sacred ceremony.
The canang sari is placed at every doorway, every shrine, every crossroads — every day.*

The invisible world is not a theological proposition.

It is a practical reality that every member of the community actively maintains.

The gamelan's first note is Zep Tepi.

The cremation fire is the transformation that makes ancestors of the beloved dead.

Bali does not separate these things. It never has.

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Introduction

Why Bali Is Different

There is a reason that travelers who visit Bali often describe it as unlike anywhere else on earth. It is not the beaches or the terraced rice fields, as spectacular as these are. It is the atmosphere: the sense of moving through a world in which every location, every moment, every action is embedded in a web of sacred meaning — in which the invisible world is not a theological proposition but a practical reality that every member of the community actively maintains through daily practice.

Bali is the last surviving Hindu island in the Indonesian archipelago — an island of approximately four million people who have maintained a distinctive form of Hinduism (known as Agama Hindu Dharma or Agama Tirtha — the Religion of Holy Water) through five centuries of Islamic expansion throughout the rest of Indonesia, three centuries of Dutch colonial rule, and the pressures of modern tourism and globalization. This survival is not passive. Balinese Hinduism is maintained through a density of daily, weekly, monthly, and annual ritual practice that is without parallel in the world — an entire society organized around the continuous performance of sacred ceremony.

History

How Bali Became the Island of the Gods

Bali's distinctive religious culture is the product of several millennia of Indian cultural and religious influence on Southeast Asia, combined with a pre-existing Austronesian indigenous culture of ancestor veneration, agricultural ritual, and animist spirituality. Beginning around the 1st century CE, Indian traders, priests, and missionaries began traveling to the Indonesian archipelago, bringing with them Sanskrit, Brahminic Hinduism, Buddhism, and Indian artistic and architectural traditions.

The Majapahit Empire (1293-1527 CE) — the last great Hindu-Buddhist empire of Indonesia — had enormous cultural influence on Bali, and when the Majapahit fell to advancing Islamic sultanates, large numbers of Majapahit nobles, priests, artists, and craftspeople migrated to Bali, bringing with them the courtly Hindu-Buddhist culture. This migration in the 15th-16th centuries CE is the defining event in Balinese cultural history — transforming Bali into the specific, intensely developed Hindu-Balinese culture that survives today.

The Puputan — Sacred Resistance to Dutch Conquest

Dutch colonial presence in Bali was established gradually from the early 17th century, with full military conquest completed only in the early 20th century. The most dramatic moment of Balinese resistance was the puputan (from the Balinese word for "ending") — the ritual mass suicide performed by Balinese royal courts rather than submit to Dutch domination. In September 1906, the Dutch military marched on the royal court of Badung. The king and hundreds of his court — dressed in white cremation clothes, carrying their keris (ceremonial daggers) and family heirlooms — processed out to meet the Dutch forces and walked into their gunfire. Similar events occurred at Klungkung in 1908. The puputan was not mere suicidal despair but a specific Balinese ritual response: to die with honor, in full ceremonial dignity, rather than to live in defeat.

Agama Hindu Dharma

Balinese Hinduism

Balinese Hinduism — officially called Agama Hindu Dharma (the Religion of the Hindu Dharma) or Agama Tirtha (the Religion of Holy Water) — is recognizably Hindu in its scriptures, its pantheon, its cosmology, and its ritual vocabulary, but distinctively Balinese in almost every aspect of its practice, its aesthetic, and its social organization. To an Indian Hindu, Balinese Hinduism looks both familiar and profoundly different — which is precisely what it is: a 1,500-year creative adaptation of Indian religious materials to an island culture with its own indigenous traditions.

Several features distinguish Agama Hindu Dharma from Indian Hinduism. The ancestor cult is far more prominent — the deified ancestors of each community are worshipped alongside the great Hindu deities, and the temple system exists primarily to house and honor these ancestors. The integration with Balinese indigenous animist and agricultural religion is complete — there is no meaningful distinction between "high Hindu" and "folk" religious practice. The arts — dance, music, sculpture, weaving, woodcarving — are understood as sacred practice rather than entertainment or decoration. And the ritual density is extraordinary.

The Two Priests — Pedanda and Pemangku

The Pedanda is the high Brahmin priest — a Sanskrit-educated ritual specialist who performs the most elaborate ceremonies, creates holy water (tirtha), and conducts the most sacred rites. The Pedanda's ritual power derives from mastery of Sanskrit mantra, ability to invoke the divine through precisely executed ritual sequences, and the accumulated spiritual potency (taksu) of lineage and practice. The Pemangku is the temple priest — drawn from all castes, often hereditary to a specific temple, serving as the primary ritual servant of that temple's deity and the first point of contact for ordinary worshippers.

The Balinese Cosmos

Sekala, Niskala, and Bhuwana

The most fundamental cosmological distinction in Balinese Hinduism is the division of reality into sekala (the visible, tangible, measurable world) and niskala (the invisible, intangible, spiritual world). These are not separate realms that occasionally interact — they are two aspects of a single reality that are always and everywhere interpenetrating.

Sekala encompasses everything that can be perceived with the ordinary senses: physical matter, measurable time and space, the social world of human relationships, the biological world of birth and death. Sekala is not considered inferior or unspiritual — it is the proper domain of human life, the field in which the spiritual work of a human incarnation is carried out. Balinese Hinduism is emphatically world-affirming: the material world is not an illusion to be escaped but a sacred opportunity to be lived well.

Niskala encompasses the gods, the ancestors, the spirits, the forces of cosmic order and disorder that are constantly present and active in the world but not visible to ordinary perception. The goal of Balinese ritual practice is not to access the niskala from a separate sekala existence but to maintain the balance and harmony of the sekala-niskala relationship.

Bhuwana Alit and Bhuwana Agung

Underlying all Balinese ceremony is a crucial cosmological pair: Bhuwana Alit (the "small world" — the human body and individual consciousness) and Bhuwana Agung (the "great world" — the universe itself). These two worlds are understood as reflections of each other, existing within one another. In the Melasti purification ceremony, both are cleansed simultaneously: the sacred objects and the participants are purified together, because the purification of the individual (Bhuwana Alit) and the purification of the world (Bhuwana Agung) are the same act. This is not metaphor — it is Balinese metaphysics: the microcosm and macrocosm are the same being in different scales.

The Mountain-Sea Axis

Balinese sacred geography is organized around the mountain-sea axis. Mount Agung (Gunung Agung — the Great Mountain) is the supreme sacred site of Bali — the home of the gods, the axis connecting the highest divine realm with the earth, the direction of purity and the divine. Toward the sea (kelod) is the direction of impurity, of the bhuta kala, of the lower forces. Every Balinese home, temple, and village is oriented in relation to this axis.

Bhuta Kala — The Disturbing Forces

The niskala world is inhabited by a vast range of beings — from the highest divine manifestations to the bhuta kala: spirits of disturbance that inhabit crossroads, cemeteries, waste ground, and the lower levels of the cosmic order, and that can cause illness, misfortune, and social disorder if not properly acknowledged. Balinese ritual practice includes extensive provisions for the bhuta kala — low offerings (caru) placed on the ground to appease these lower forces. This is not fearful propitiation but practical management of the full spectrum of invisible presences that inhabit the world.

The Gods

Sang Hyang Widhi Wasa and the Divine Manifestations

At the apex of the Balinese divine order is Sang Hyang Widhi Wasa — the supreme divine being, the one God who encompasses and transcends all other divine manifestations. Sang Hyang Widhi Wasa (meaning approximately "the divine supreme order" or "the all-pervading lord") is understood as formless, infinite, and beyond all conceptual definition — the Absolute that cannot be directly grasped by the human mind. This is the Balinese expression of the same recognition that appears in Advaita Vedanta as Brahman, in the Heliopolitan theology of Atum, and in the Tao as the nameless source.

The Tri Murti — The Three Great Divine Manifestations

Sang Hyang Widhi Wasa manifests in creation through three primary aspects — the Tri Murti. Brahma is the Creator — associated with the south direction and the color red. Wisnu (Vishnu) is the Preserver — associated with the north direction and the color black. Siwa (Shiva) is the Transformer — the most important of the three in Balinese Hindu practice, associated with the center direction and the color white.

The Dewata Nawa Sanga — Nine Directional Deities

The Balinese cosmic geography recognizes nine sacred directions (the four cardinal directions, the four intermediate directions, and the center) each associated with a specific deity, color, and quality. Together these nine deities form the divine framework within which all earthly existence takes place. The sacred nine-directional mandala appears throughout Balinese ritual and artistic life — in temple layouts, in cremation towers, in offerings, and in the alignment of sacred spaces.

The Ancestor Gods — Dewa Hyang

Alongside the great Hindu deities, the Balinese honor the deified ancestors (Dewa Hyang or Pitara) of each family and community. The most powerful of a community's ancestors have, through accumulated spiritual merit and continued engagement with the world of the living, achieved a divine status — they are not simply honored dead but active divine beings who protect, guide, and sustain their descendants. The temple system exists primarily to provide proper homes for these ancestral deities, and the majority of Balinese ceremonies are directed as much toward the ancestral deities as toward the great Hindu divine manifestations.

The Tri Hita Karana

The Three Causes of Well-Being

The most important philosophical concept in contemporary Balinese religious and social life is the Tri Hita Karana — the Three Causes of Well-Being. This principle organizes all Balinese thought about the good life, the healthy community, and the right relationship between human beings and their world. It was formally recognized when UNESCO inscribed Bali's subak system as a World Heritage Site in 2012, specifically as a "Manifestation of the Tri Hita Karana Philosophy."

PARAHYANGAN — Harmony with the Divine

The first cause of well-being is right relationship with the divine — the gods, the ancestors, and the sacred forces that pervade the world. This is maintained through the temple system, the ceremonial calendar, the daily offerings, the priest traditions, and all the specific practices that constitute Balinese ritual life.

PAWONGAN — Harmony with Fellow Human Beings

The second cause of well-being is right relationship with the human community — the family, the village (banjar), the caste group, and the broader Balinese society. The banjar system — in which every household is a member of a neighborhood association responsible for collective ritual, infrastructure, and social welfare — is the primary institution of Balinese community life and the main vehicle through which Pawongan is maintained.

PALEMAHAN — Harmony with the Natural World

The third cause of well-being is right relationship with the natural world — the land, the waters, the plants, the animals, and the physical environment. This includes the subak system (the ancient cooperative rice irrigation system, designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2012), the ritual relationship with specific trees, springs, and mountain sites, the agricultural ceremonies that honor the rice goddess Dewi Sri at each stage of the rice cycle, and the broader orientation toward the natural world as a sacred, inhabited, and responsive presence.

The Caste System

Warna and Balinese Social Order

The Balinese caste system (warna, also called wangsa) organizes Balinese society into four primary groups: Brahmin (the priest caste), Ksatria (the warrior/noble caste), Wesya (the merchant/administrative caste), and Sudra (the commoner caste, comprising approximately 90% of the Balinese population). The Balinese caste system is both less rigid and more complex than its Indian counterpart. Most Balinese people (the approximately 90% Sudra) have full participation in ritual life — they serve as temple priests, lead community ceremonies, and access the divine directly through their own prayers and offerings. The caste system's primary surviving function is as a marker of family lineage and ancestral identity, not a determinant of social worth or spiritual access.

Daily Offerings

Canang Sari and the Practice of Constant Devotion

The most immediate and visible expression of Balinese Hinduism is the daily offering — the canang sari — placed throughout the day at shrines, doorways, roads, and any other location where the divine or potentially disturbing forces are present. The canang sari is the heartbeat of Balinese religious life: the daily, hourly reminder that the practitioner exists in a world of invisible presences that require acknowledgment and care.

The name canang sari comes from two sources: canang (from the Kawi *ca* + *nang*, meaning "beautiful purpose") and sari (essence or best part). A canang sari is a small palm-leaf tray, folded and pinned into a specific shape by hand, filled with flowers arranged by color according to directional symbolism, along with incense, sometimes a small biscuit or cracker, and a coin or small amount of currency. The average Balinese woman makes between 20 and 80 canang sari per day. The making of offerings is simultaneously prayer, meditation, artistic expression, and relationship maintenance.

The philosophy behind the canang sari is the same as the Tri Hita Karana: it serves to honor the gods (Parahyangan), maintain goodwill toward disturbing spirits so they leave the community in peace (the lower caru offerings), and express gratitude to the natural world for the materials it provides (Palemahan). Each offering is activated by burning incense (dupa) — the smoke carrying the offering's intention and essence to the divine presences for whom it is intended.

How to Make and Place the Canang Sari

Step by Step

The making of the canang sari is traditionally women's work in Balinese Hindu households — a skill passed down through generations, performed with a focused, meditative quality early in the morning, after household chores and bathing are complete. The woman who makes offerings dresses respectfully in a sarong and sash before the ritual.

Making the Offering

STEP 1 — THE CEPÉR (TRAY): From strips of coconut palm leaf (janur), fold and weave a small square tray — pinching, tucking, and folding the leaf, securing the corners with tiny slivers of palm midrib. This is the physical container for the offering. The making of the tray itself is the first meditative act.

STEP 2 — THE PEPOROSAN (CORE): Place the core materials inside: a piece of betel leaf (symbolizing Shiva), a slice of lime or gambier (symbolizing Brahma), and betel nut (symbolizing Vishnu). These three materials encode the Tri Murti — the three great Hindu gods — in the heart of every daily offering, so that even the smallest canang sari is a statement of the complete divine reality.

STEP 3 — THE FLOWERS (RAKA-RAKA): Arrange fresh flowers by the directional color symbolism: white flowers pointing east (toward Iswara, the eastern deity of the Dewata Nawa Sanga), red flowers toward the south (Brahma), yellow flowers toward the west (Mahadewa), and blue or green flowers toward the north (Wisnu). The flower arrangement is the visual heart of the offering.

STEP 4 — FINISHING ELEMENTS: Add a few ribbons of pandan leaf for fragrance and texture, a small pinch of uncooked rice (representing life and sustenance), and optionally a small coin (acknowledging material gratitude and the earthly realm). Lay a single unlit stick of incense (dupa) across the top.

STEP 5 — ACTIVATION: Sprinkle a few drops of holy water (tirtha) over the completed offering to purify and activate it. Then light the incense stick. The smoke carries the offering's intention and essence to the divine presences.

STEP 6 — THE PRAYER (PUJA): Hold the offering in both hands at chest height. Perform the silent or quiet prayer (mantra) appropriate to the shrine or location where the offering will be placed. The specific words vary by family tradition, but the intention is always: gratitude, acknowledgment, and the maintenance of right relationship.

STEP 7 — PLACEMENT: Place the offering at the appropriate location — household shrine, kitchen shrine, front gate, a small ground-level platform for the bhuta kala (the low offerings, placed on the ground rather than elevated). Place with care and mindfulness. The offering has now done its work when the incense has burned out.

Canang sari are not offered when there is a death in the community or family — in those circumstances, all normal ritual life pauses as the community turns its full attention to the mortuary ceremonies. They are offered with intensified care on Kajeng Kliwon (every 15 days), Purnama (full moon), and Tilem (new moon). After the incense has burned out, the physical components have served their purpose and may be swept away — the sari (essence) has been received.

The Temple System

Pura and Sacred Architecture

Bali has an estimated 20,000 temples (pura) — approximately one temple for every 200 people. This extraordinary density of sacred architecture is a direct expression of the Balinese understanding that every location, every social group, and every aspect of life requires its own dedicated sacred space.

Every traditional Balinese village has three primary temples. The Pura Desa is the village temple proper — the place of community ceremony and home of the village's protective deities. The Pura Puseh is the "navel" temple — oriented toward Mount Agung, associated with the origin and ancestry of the village community. The Pura Dalem is the temple of the dead — associated with Siwa in his transformative aspect and with the deified ancestors. Located at the village's kelod (sea-ward) end, it serves as the ritual home of the dead and the site of cremation ceremonies.

A traditional Balinese temple is an open-air compound rather than an enclosed building — a series of courtyards separated by split gates (candi bentar, symbolizing the separation between the sekala and niskala worlds). Every temple has its own birthday (odalan), celebrated every 210 days according to the Pawukon calendar — the day when the divine presences who inhabit the temple are most fully present, when the most elaborate offerings are prepared, when the sacred dances are performed.

Pura Besakih

The Mother Temple

Pura Besakih — the Mother Temple of Bali — is the most important, largest, and holiest temple in Balinese Hinduism, perched nearly 1,000 meters up the southwestern slopes of Mount Agung, the sacred mountain. It is not a single temple but an extensive complex of 23 separate but related temples, with the largest and most important being Pura Penataran Agung. The complex is built on six terraced levels, ascending the slope of the volcano toward the divine.

Besakih is the only temple in Bali where Hindus of all castes are permitted to worship together. Its sacred status is confirmed in a famous historical event: during the catastrophic eruption of Mount Agung in 1963, which killed approximately 1,700 people, lava flows came within 15 meters of the outermost walls of Pura Penataran Agung — and stopped. The Balinese interpreted this as a divine miracle, confirmation that the gods were demonstrating their power while protecting their earthly residence. The temple has been on the UNESCO World Heritage tentative list since 1995.

Each year, at least 70 festivals are held at the Besakih complex based on the 210-day Pawukon calendar. The most important is the Bhatara Turun Kabeh Ceremony, held during the full moon of the Balinese month Kedasa (April-May), when all the gods are believed to simultaneously descend to the complex and when enormous crowds of pilgrims from across Bali make the journey up the mountain to honor their presence. Once every 100 years, the great Ekadasa Rudra ceremony is held at Besakih — the most comprehensive purification ceremony in Bali, involving the entire island.

The Balinese Calendar System

Saka and Pawukon

The Balinese use two interlocking calendar systems simultaneously — the Saka calendar (a Hindu lunar-solar calendar) and the Pawukon (a Balinese cycle calendar of 210 days) — creating one of the most complex sacred timekeeping systems in the world.

The Saka calendar is derived from the Indian Saka calendar, adjusted for Balinese use. It determines the dates of major ceremonies including Nyepi (the Day of Silence — Balinese New Year) and Galungan and Kuningan. It also tracks the lunar phases significant in Balinese ritual: the full moon (Purnama) and new moon (Tilem) are both monthly occasions for intensified prayer and offering.

The Pawukon is the distinctively Balinese sacred calendar — a 210-day cycle divided into 30 weeks of 7 days each. Multiple simultaneously running week-cycles of different lengths create a continuous, complex field of sacred timing. The most important is the intersection of the 5-day market week (Panca Wara) and the 7-day week (Sapta Wara). Kajeng Kliwon — the combination of Kliwon (fifth day of the 5-day week) with specific days of the 7-day week — occurs every 15 days and is considered a time of intensified spiritual activity.

Galungan and Kuningan

The most important Balinese festivals occur every 210 days according to the Pawukon calendar. Galungan celebrates the victory of dharma over adharma — it is the day when the ancestral spirits return to earth to visit their descendants, when the streets are lined with tall bamboo penjor decorated with fruits and flowers, and when every household prepares elaborate offerings to welcome the returning ancestors. Kuningan, ten days later, is the day the ancestors return to the spirit world — honored with yellow rice (nasi kuning) and the final offerings of the period.

Major Ceremonies and Ritual Life

Balinese ritual life encompasses ceremonies for every stage of human life from conception to cremation, every stage of the rice cycle, every threshold and junction of the sacred calendar. Estimates suggest that the average Balinese household devotes 30-40% of its income to ceremony.

The Life-Cycle Ceremonies (Manusa Yadnya)

From the moment of conception, a Balinese person's life is accompanied by ceremony. The tooth filing ceremony (mepandes or mesangih) — in which the upper six teeth are symbolically filed flat — is the most important coming-of-age rite: it removes the "animalistic" points from the teeth and symbolically completes the person's transition from animal to human, from nature to culture, from instinct to dharma.

The Agricultural Ceremonies (Dewa Yadnya)

The rice cycle in Bali is embedded in ceremony from beginning to end. The subak system — the ancient cooperative rice irrigation system, managed through water temples and their priest-led ceremonies — distributes water equitably among farmers through a democratic network that dates to at least the 9th century. At each stage of the rice's growth — planting, first sprouting, flowering, first appearance of the grain head, and harvest — specific ceremonies are held in the subak temples. The rice goddess Dewi Sri, whose image appears in woven rice stalks hung at the entrance of every Balinese home during harvest time, is honored throughout.

The Melasti Ceremony

Purification at the Sea

The Melasti ceremony (also known as Melis or Mekiis — from the Sanskrit mala ["dirt"] + asti ["to throw away"]) is one of the most important rituals in Balinese Hinduism. Held three to four days before Nyepi (the Day of Silence), it marks the beginning of the Balinese New Year observance. It is the island's greatest communal purification: the simultaneous cleansing of Bhuwana Alit (the human body and soul) and Bhuwana Agung (the universe itself).

In Balinese Hindu belief, water — especially sea water — holds the essence of everlasting life (Tirtha Amerta). The sea is the ultimate source of purification: into it, all impurities, bad karma, and negative energies accumulated over the past year can be released. The Melasti ceremony brings entire village communities to the sea to accomplish this release and to renew the spiritual power of the sacred objects that will serve the community through the coming year.

The Ceremony — Step by Step

PREPARATION: In the days before Melasti, women prepare elaborate offerings: Canang Sari, Daksina (a cone-shaped offering of rice and flowers), Banten Suci, and other symbolic paraphernalia. Sacred objects are gathered from the temple — pratima (sacred images), arca (statues), ceremonial implements — to be carried to the sea for purification.

STEP 1 — THE MAPEED PROCESSION: The entire village community gathers in traditional attire — white and yellow, the colors of purity and spiritual elevation. Women balance offerings and sacred objects on their heads; men carry the pratima shrines on their shoulders. Balinese umbrellas (tedung) and sacred flags (umbul-umbul) mark the procession. The penabuh play the gamelan as the procession moves toward the water.

STEP 2 — ARRIVAL AT THE SEA: At the water's edge, the sacred objects are arranged on a table or platform facing the sea. The assembled community sits on the ground in prayer posture. Priests set up the ceremonial space.

STEP 3 — THE PRIESTLY RITUAL: The Hindu priest (Pemangku or Pedanda) chants mantras while ringing a holy bell, sprinkles holy water over the sacred objects, and performs specific prayers for each item. Some worshippers enter trance (surupan) during this intensely charged moment.

STEP 4 — PURIFICATION OF SACRED OBJECTS: The sacred statues and ceremonial objects are immersed in or washed with sea water — the water of Tirtha Amerta — restoring their spiritual power and releasing any accumulated negative energy they have absorbed over the past year.

STEP 5 — PURIFICATION OF PARTICIPANTS: The priest flicks Tirtha (holy water collected from the sea) over the assembled worshippers and gives them Bija (holy rice). Some participants also enter the water to physically cleanse themselves. This act simultaneously purifies Bhuwana Alit (the individual) and Bhuwana Agung (the world).

STEP 6 — RETURN PROCESSION: The sacred objects, now purified and renewed, are carried back to the temple in procession. The holy water collected from the sea is also brought back and stored for ceremonial use. The community returns to the temple for final prayers and to restore the sacred objects to their proper places.

The Melasti ceremony takes place on beaches across Bali simultaneously, creating a day of remarkable visual beauty — thousands of people in white and yellow processing toward the sea. Sanur, Kuta, Nusa Dua, and Jimbaran beaches receive the largest processions.

Nyepi

The Day of Silence

Nyepi — the Balinese New Year according to the Saka calendar — is one of the most extraordinary religious observances in the world. It is the Day of Silence: a 24-hour period during which the entire island of Bali shuts down completely. No vehicles move on the roads. No electric lights are turned on. No work is done. No one leaves their home compound. Even the international airport at Denpasar is closed for the day. The island, with its four million residents and significant tourist population, enters a state of complete external stillness.

Nyepi is governed by four prohibitions (Catur Brata Penyepian): no fire or light (Amati Geni), no work or activity (Amati Karya), no travel (Amati Lelungan), and no entertainment or pleasure (Amati Lelanguan). These four prohibitions create a day of total outer stillness intended to generate corresponding inner stillness — a day of meditation, reflection, and spiritual renewal. The silence is enforced by community patrol members (pecalang) who walk the streets, and the entire island literally goes dark at night.

The Night Before — Ogoh-Ogoh Processions

The evening before Nyepi is the opposite of the day itself. Young men from each banjar have spent weeks constructing ogoh-ogoh — enormous papier-mache sculptures of demonic beings, terrifying and magnificent in equal measure, lit with torches and carried through the streets on bamboo platforms. The procession (nggrupuk or penggrupukan) moves through the village with as much noise, light, and energy as possible. The purpose: to rouse all the disturbing spirits of the area, make them visible by attracting them, and then confuse and drive them away. At the end of the procession, the ogoh-ogoh are burned — the disturbing forces symbolically destroyed in the fire before the year begins. (In 2024, the Ogoh-Ogoh parades were cancelled across Bali due to the proximity of the Indonesian general election, with fears the sculptures might convey political themes — a rare interruption of an ancient tradition.)

The day after Nyepi is Ngembak Geni — "lighting the fire" — a day of forgiveness and reconciliation where people visit families and friends to ask for forgiveness and start anew.

Cremation

Ngaben and the Journey of the Soul

The Balinese cremation ceremony — Ngaben (from the Balinese word for fire) or Pitra Yadnya (offering to the ancestors) — is one of the most extraordinary funerary practices in the world. For the Balinese, cremation is not a mournful event but a joyful one: the ceremony that frees the soul (atma) from its attachment to the physical body and its earthly circumstances, allowing it to continue its journey toward reunion with the divine. The body is understood as a transient shell made of earth, air, fire, water, and space — ultimately meaningless, but having served as a container for the immortal soul.

Balinese Hindu theology holds that there is a competition between evil residents of the lower realm to capture the departing soul, and that a proper cremation enhances the chance that the soul may reach the upper realm. When the body dies, the soul remains in the vicinity — partially confused by its new condition and still attached to the things and people it knew. It requires regular prayers and offerings to keep it oriented and comfortable during the interim period before cremation.

The Interim Period — Temporary Burial

A quick Ngaben is preferred but usually too expensive. Most ordinary families temporarily bury the body — sometimes for days, sometimes for years — while saving the resources needed for a proper ceremony. Multiple families often join together for a mass cremation (Ngaben Ngirim) to share costs. The body is buried near Pura Prajapati, the temple associated with death, which keeps it in sacred proximity. During this period, the soul requires regular prayers and the guidance of a balian (Balinese healer/medium) who can facilitate communication with the dead.

Ngaben

Step by Step

STEP 1 — CHOOSING THE DATE: The family and high priest select an auspicious day for the cremation according to the Balinese calendar. The community (banjar) is convened, and every member contributes: coconuts, bamboo, rice. Women prepare offerings (which can take weeks). Men begin constructing the cremation structures.

STEP 2 — THE BADE (CREMATION TOWER): Men build the bade (also called wadah) — a multi-tiered tower of wood, bamboo, paper, and fabric that serves as the soul's temporary palace and vehicle for its journey. The number of tiers corresponds to the deceased's caste and status: from 3 tiers for ordinary commoners to 11 tiers for the highest Brahmin. The tiers represent levels of the cosmos. The tower can reach 10-20 meters for royal families.

STEP 3 — THE PATULANGAN (SARCOPHAGUS): Simultaneously, the patulangan is constructed — an animal-shaped sarcophagus made of wood, paper mache, and gold leaf, mounted on a platform. The animal reflects the deceased's gender and status: a lembu (bull or ox) for men and Brahmin priests (the bull is the vehicle of Shiva, God of transformation); a cow for women. The animal is understood as the vehicle that carries the soul forward.

STEP 4 — MEMUKUR (BODY PREPARATION): The body is exhumed or brought from the family compound. Family and friends gather, dressed in traditional ceremonial attire (not black — Ngaben is a celebration of liberation, not a mourning). The Memukur ritual: the family washes the body with holy water (tirtha), dresses it in Balinese attire, and wraps it in white fabric. The body may be decorated with flowers, leaves, and gold. Family and close friends pay their respects with prayers.

STEP 5 — THE PROCESSION: The body is placed in the bade (cremation tower), which is mounted on a bamboo platform and carried on the shoulders of dozens of men from the family and banjar through the village streets. The gamelan plays beleganjur music — a battle song symbolizing the soul's fight with evil underworld forces to reach the upper realm. The bade is deliberately rotated and spun at every intersection — three times — to confuse and disorient any evil spirits that might try to follow the soul to the cremation ground.

STEP 6 — THE FIRE: At the cremation ground (kuburan), final hymns are recited. The Brahmin priest lights the cremation fire. The body is transferred from the bade into the patulangan (the animal sarcophagus), which is then ignited. The fire — understood as Siwa's transformative force — is not destruction but purification and liberation. As the fire consumes the body and the elaborate structures, the family and community celebrate rather than mourn. There may be singing, laughter, expressions of gratitude for the completion of a good life.

STEP 7 — THE ASHES TO THE SEA: After the fire, the family gathers the ashes and bone fragments — ideally within 12 days — and carries them to the sea or a nearby river. The ashes are placed in a coconut shell and ceremonially scattered in the water. This final act symbolizes the soul's return to the cosmic ocean of potential from which all life comes. Ceremonies accompany this with music and offerings.

STEP 8 — NGERORAS AND NYENENG: In the twelve days following cremation, daily ceremonies accompany the soul on its journey. Eventually the soul undergoes melukat — a purification ceremony — and then nyeneng, in which it is formally elevated to the status of ancestral deity (Dewa Hyang), able to receive worship and offer protection to its descendants from the niskala world.

Sacred Arts

Dance, Music, and Shadow Puppetry

In Bali, the distinction between art and religion does not exist. The traditional arts — dance, music (gamelan), sculpture, painting, weaving, shadow puppet theater (wayang kulit) — are not cultural products produced for aesthetic enjoyment or commercial exchange. They are sacred practices: ways of honoring the divine, creating beauty as an offering, and maintaining the living connection between the sekala and niskala worlds.

The Gamelan — Sacred Sound

The gamelan is the orchestra at the heart of Balinese ceremonial life — a percussion ensemble of gongs, metallophones, drums, and other instruments. The tuning of a Balinese gamelan is unique to each set of instruments — no two gamelans are identically tuned, and the specific sound of a village's gamelan is understood as carrying that village's spiritual character. Balinese gamelan music operates through complex interlocking patterns (kotekan) in which two players together execute a single, rapid melodic line — neither player can produce the complete pattern alone. This musical philosophy encodes the social philosophy: the most beautiful things emerge from genuine collaboration.

Sacred Dance — The Body as Offering

Balinese sacred dance is among the most technically demanding and spiritually profound dance traditions in the world. Dancers begin training as young children. In the most sacred forms of Balinese dance, the dancer enters a state of divine possession (kerawuhan) — the god or ancestor whose story they are enacting actually enters and animates their body.

Wayang Kulit — The Shadow Theater

The wayang kulit (shadow puppet theater) is simultaneously an art form, a teaching vehicle, a healing ceremony, and a form of prayer. The dalang (puppet master) must undergo years of training, ritual purification, and ongoing spiritual discipline. A wayang performance typically lasts all night, presenting episodes from the great Hindu epics through the voices of dozens of leather puppet characters. The lamp behind the puppet screen is the divine presence — the dalang holds the puppets between the lamp and the screen, and the shadows that appear are understood as the shadows of divine reality made visible in the world of appearances.

Balinese Healers

Balian and the Unseen World

The balian is the Balinese traditional healer — a figure whose role combines what Western culture would separate into doctor, priest, psychologist, spiritual counselor, and medium. Balian work with the interface between the sekala and niskala worlds — diagnosing and treating illnesses that have spiritual components, communicating with the ancestors and divine presences on behalf of their clients, and facilitating the resolution of spiritual disturbances affecting physical or social wellbeing.

There are several recognized categories of balian. The balian usada works with ancient palm-leaf medical manuscripts (lontar usada) containing extensive knowledge of herbal medicine, massage, and the treatment of physical conditions. The balian taksu is a medium — entering trance states to allow ancestral or divine presences to speak through them. The balian apun specializes in setting broken bones and treating physical injuries. The balian tenung is a diviner who reads signs to diagnose the spiritual roots of problems.

Taksu — Divine Grace

Central to Balinese healing and sacred arts practice is the concept of taksu — a divine grace or spiritual power that enables exceptional performance, healing ability, or sacred presence. Taksu is not a permanent personal attribute but a divine gift that comes and goes — it is most available to those who have prepared themselves through proper ritual observance, ethical conduct, artistic dedication, and the maintenance of right relationship with the divine. A dancer with taksu moves differently from one without — observers describe a quality of luminosity, of divine presence animating the body that transcends technical skill. Taksu is what Haligrity might recognize as the Awen of the Druidic tradition, or the anointing of the Christian mystical tradition.

Kecak, Barong, and the Battle Between Good and Evil

Two of the most famous Balinese ritual performance forms — the Kecak and the Barong dance — present the Balinese cosmological understanding of the relationship between the forces of order and chaos in particularly vivid form.

The Kecak — The Human Orchestra

The Kecak is a ceremonial form in which a large group of male performers — typically 100 or more — sit in concentric circles and provide the entire musical accompaniment through their voices alone, chanting interlocking patterns of "cak-cak-cak" while swaying, raising their arms, and performing gestures that illustrate the story of the Ramayana epic. The Kecak began as a sacred trance ritual (the sanghyang dedari ceremony) and was transformed into its current form in the 1930s through the collaboration of the German artist Walter Spies and the Balinese dancer I Wayan Limbak.

The Barong and Rangda — The Living Cosmic Drama

The Barong is a lion-like protective creature representing the forces of dharma — cosmic order, benevolence, and the protection of the community. The Rangda is Barong's adversary — a terrifying widow-witch figure representing the forces of chaos, disease, and disruption. In the ceremony, Barong and Rangda engage in an endless battle that is never conclusively won by either side. The warriors who join Barong's side are periodically seized by Rangda's magic and turned against themselves — pointing their keris daggers at their own chests in a state of trance. Barong's magic protects them from actual harm. Eventually the battle ends in standoff.

The crucial theological point of the Barong-Rangda drama is that neither side wins permanently. In Balinese cosmology, the balance between the forces of order and chaos is not a problem to be solved but the fundamental nature of reality. The Rangda is not to be eliminated — she is to be maintained in right relationship. The ritual drama enacts this understanding publicly, in the community, as a shared experience of the truth that cosmic balance is not a static condition but an ongoing dynamic negotiation.

Bali Today

Overtourism and the Sacred Under Pressure

The most significant contemporary challenge to Balinese sacred life is not religious persecution or the suppression of ceremony — it is the sheer weight of global tourism and its consequences for a culture whose sacred and social fabric are inseparable from its daily life. In 2024, Bali received 6.33 million international visitors — a new record, a 20.1% increase over 2023, and nearly double the island's resident population of 4.4 million. Together with 22.64 million domestic visitors, the total visitor load in 2024 was historically unprecedented.

The consequences are direct and serious: sacred sites overrun with tourists seeking Instagram content rather than spiritual experience. Besakih Temple — the holiest site in Balinese Hinduism — and Lempuyang Temple's "Gates of Heaven" have both been transformed, in many visitors' practice, into backdrop photography locations. Tegallalang Rice Terrace, which is embedded in the subak ceremonial system, has been overrun to the point where the sacred function of the landscape is increasingly submerged in commercial activity. Religious ceremonies, once reserved for the community, are increasingly transformed into performances for tourist audiences — a commodification that hollows out their sacred character.

In response, Governor Wayan Koster issued Circular Letter No. 7 in 2025 — an updated set of regulations for foreign tourists including eight specific prohibitions: entering temple inner sanctums (*utama mandala*) unless praying in traditional Balinese attire; climbing sacred trees found in temple grounds; disrespectful behavior including public nudity, profanity, or social media posts deemed hateful or misleading; and illegal activities. A tourist levy of IDR 150,000 (approximately US\$10) was introduced in February 2024 — but only approximately 35% of international visitors paid it in its first year. In 2024, 340 foreigners were deported from Bali for violations including exposing themselves in sacred places.

Balinese civil society is responding. Movements like "Bali is Not for Tourists, Bali is for Balinese" signal growing frustration. The village of Penglipuran in east Bali, which uses customary law to forbid villagers from selling land to outsiders, has emerged as a model of cultural self-protection. The 2025 Bali 100-Year Development Plan (2025-2125) — the first official government document to formally acknowledge the impacts of mass tourism on the island — commits to protecting culture, nature, and the Balinese people over the long term.

The overtourism crisis is a fairness issue as well as a cultural one. An island whose entire social fabric is organized around sacred ceremony and community obligation — where 30-40% of household income goes to ceremony, where the *gambian* and the *odalan* and the *canang sari* maintain the invisible world — cannot survive the transformation of that sacred fabric into entertainment for outsiders. The Balinese have maintained their tradition through Dutch colonial rule, through Islamic expansion, through two terrorist bombings (2002 and 2005). The question of whether their tradition can survive the specific form of pressure that mass global tourism represents is one of the most urgent questions in contemporary sacred culture.

Bali and Haligricity

Where the Paths Cross

Balinese Hinduism is not a peripheral tradition in the Haligric conversation. It is one of the world's most completely integrated and sustained examples of what Haligricity holds as possible: a life in which every dimension of existence — the physical, the emotional, the social, the artistic, the ecological, and the spiritual — is woven into a single sacred fabric.

Sekala and Niskala — The Two-Dimensional World

The Balinese understanding that the visible and invisible worlds are two aspects of one reality in permanent interpenetration is the most clearly articulated ancient parallel to the Haligric understanding of the relationship between the physical body and the energy body. The Haligric practitioner who works simultaneously with the physical body and the energy body is living the sekala-niskala understanding in Haligric form.

Bhuwana Alit and Bhuwana Agung

The Balinese cosmological pair of small world (human body) and great world (universe), understood as reflections of each other existing within one another — purified together in Melasti, honored together in every offering — is the Balinese articulation of the Hermetic teaching "as above, so below" and the Haligric understanding that inner work and outer world are not separate domains but the same domain at different scales.

The Daily Offering and Sacred Practice

The Balinese canang sari — the daily offering placed multiple times at every threshold and sacred site — is the most complete ancient model of what Haligricity holds about daily practice. The Haligric rise practice, meal blessing, and daily movement and breath work are daily sacred practices in the same spirit: the recognition that a genuinely sacred life is not organized around special occasions but around the ongoing quality of daily, moment-by-moment engagement with the sacred. What the Balinese offer in palm-leaf and flowers, the Haligric practitioner offers in breath, intention, and gratitude.

The Tri Hita Karana and the Complete Life

The Balinese three causes of well-being — harmony with the divine (Parahyangan), harmony with the human community (Pawongan), and harmony with the natural world (Palemahan) — provide the most complete ancient framework for the integrated, whole-life approach that Haligricity practices. The Tetralty (Feeling, Thinking, Speaking, Doing) is the internal navigation system. The Tri Hita Karana is the external map: the three domains in which that navigation must be applied for a genuinely whole life.

Taksu and the Prepared Vessel

The Balinese concept of taksu — divine grace available to those who have prepared themselves through sustained practice, right relationship, and ethical conduct — is the Balinese name for what the Druidic tradition calls Awen, what the Christian mystical tradition calls anointing, and what the Haligric tradition recognizes as the quality of genuine creative and healing power that flows through a practitioner whose practice is genuine.

Ngaben and the Living Ancestor

The Balinese cremation ceremony understood as joyful liberation — the soul released from its earthly attachment to continue its journey, eventually elevated to the status of ancestral deity able to receive worship and offer protection to its descendants — is one of the world's most complete ritual expressions of the recognition that death is transformation rather than ending. The Haligric ancestor altar practice rests on the same

recognition: the beloved dead are not gone. They have changed their mode of presence. The relationship continues, and it requires care.

Nyepi and the Sacred Pause

The Balinese Day of Silence — an entire island entering stillness for 24 hours as an act of spiritual renewal and sacred reset — is the most dramatic collective expression in the world of the Haligric principle that genuine spiritual practice requires regular, intentional pauses: moments when the external activity ceases and the internal life can be heard.

*"The gods need beauty.
The ancestors need food.
The earth needs respect.
And the human being needs all three — at once, every day, without exception."*

— Balinese understanding, distilled from the Tri Hita Karana

What Bali teaches the world is that the sacred does not require withdrawal from ordinary life. It requires the transformation of ordinary life into sacred life — through the quality of attention, the consistency of practice, the beauty of the offering, and the recognition that the invisible world is not elsewhere but here, in every breath, at every doorstep, in every grain of rice, in every note of gamelan music rising into the tropical dusk. The canang sari placed at the threshold is the same prayer as the universe beginning. The gamelan's first note is Zep Tepi. The cremation fire is the transformation that makes ancestors of the beloved dead. Bali does not separate these things. It never has. Grand Rising.